

HOMESERVANT

App Overview

What HomeServant does, for each type of user

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Source: `docs/guides/app_overview.html` — rebuild with `python3 docs/guides/build.py`.

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1. What HomeServant is

HomeServant connects people looking for a home with landlords, and people who need home services with vendors, with payments held safely by the platform until each side has done their part. It runs in the browser (and as a mobile app) for four kinds of user:

Who	What they do
Tenants	Browse homes and shortlets, pay to rent or book, arrange inspections, move in, renew, and message landlords they've paid.
Landlords	List and manage properties, handle bookings and inspections, get paid, and message tenants.
Vendors	Run a marketplace shop once an admin approves them: products, orders, messages, payouts.
Admins	Run support and moderation from a separate web console, at three levels: Support, Moderator, Super Admin.

2. Accounts and signing in

- **Sign up** with email and password (a 4-digit code confirms the email) or with Google, then fill in a short profile. *Every profile field is required*: name, a valid Nigerian phone number, date of birth (18 or older), home address, profile photo, means of ID and its number, gender, occupation and marital status; landlords also upload a certificate of ownership and a document (a photo or PDF). Only the referral code is optional. ID details and documents are stored privately. The ID number is checked with the body that issued it (NIMC for a NIN, the FRSC for a driver's licence, INEC for a voter's card, Immigration for a passport), so a tenant whose name matches the one on record is usually verified within seconds — which is why the name on the profile has to match the name on the ID. Anything else, and every landlord (whose certificate of ownership only a person can judge), is reviewed by a HomeServant moderator, who verifies or rejects it with a reason. Verified people get a blue **Verified** check (listings from verified landlords show it on the photo and property page), and each person sees their own status on their profile. A super admin can switch on *Only verified landlords* (Platform Controls), which hides unverified landlords' listings from tenants and blocks new bookings on them. Tenants who already booked or saved one still see it, marked as hidden because the landlord is unverified, and their booking carries on. Unverified landlords are notified and can submit their documents from *Get verified* on their profile or dashboard. A second switch, *Pay unverified landlords* (on by default), decides whether unverified landlords are paid as normal or have their payouts held by HomeServant until they are verified; tenants are never affected either way. An unfinished signup can be picked up again with the same email.
- **Sign in** on the tenant/landlord page (or the marketplace for vendors). Optional extras in Settings: *Two-Factor Authentication* (an emailed code at every sign-in) and *App Lock* (a PIN whenever the app reopens).
- **Forgot password** sends a reset code by email.
- **Deactivate** hides the account; signing in again reactivates it. **Delete** removes it for good.
- **Each sign-in page only takes its own kind of account.** A landlord on the tenant sign-in page (or a tenant on the landlord page) is told which page to use, with a button to switch; the same goes for "Continue with Google". Vendors sign in on the tenant page (a shop belongs to a tenant account). **Admins** sign in only on the admin console's own page; the regular sign-in pages, and Google sign-in, refuse admin accounts.

3. Tenants

Finding a home

- The dashboard opens on **All** listings, each labelled with its category; tabs narrow it to House, Shortlet, Self-Con or Apartment. Search by name or area, and filter by price and location. The price boxes start empty (the category's price range shows as a hint), so tenants just type a minimum, a maximum or both.
- A property page shows photos, the landlord's walkthrough video, details, rating and reviews. Save favourites to the **Wishlist**.
- **Rented homes drop off the list:** once a tenant has moved into a rental, it is no longer shown to other tenants. It comes back when the lease ends. Before that, while a tenant has paid but not yet moved in, the listing stays visible but no one else can pay for it; it opens up again if that booking is refunded or rejected. This happens live: a listing someone else has just moved into disappears from other tenants' screens within seconds, without a refresh. Shortlets stay listed with an "available again" countdown.
- **Search order is fair:** listings that can be booked now come first (a booked-out shortlet shows after them), and promoted listings — paid **Featured** ads, which are always labelled, and listings HomeServant ranks up — take at most one spot in every few results; the rest are the newest listings.
- **Report this listing** (bottom of a property page) sends a scam, misleading photos, a request to pay outside HomeServant and so on to HomeServant's team; available once the tenant has booked, messaged about or saved the listing. *Settings* → *My Reports* shows their reports and whether they've been reviewed.
- **Booking profile** (Edit Profile): a short *About me* and hobbies, shown with the profile photo to landlords and shortlet owners when a booking request comes in.

Renting a home (House, Self-Con, Apartment)

1. **Rent Now** takes payment straight away: the Paystack checkout opens in the same tab and returns to HomeServant afterwards, which confirms the payment at once and takes the tenant back to their dashboard, still signed in. The money is *held* by HomeServant, not paid to the landlord yet.
2. **One booking per home:** once paid, the property page shows *You've paid for this property* with a link to Booking History instead of Rent Now, so it can't be paid for twice. A checkout that was started but not paid is picked up again (Rent Now or *Complete Payment* in Booking History) rather than creating a second booking.
3. Book an inspection date (now, later from Booking History, or from the chat with the landlord) and change it until the landlord answers. The landlord confirms or declines it, or sets a date themselves, even if the tenant hasn't proposed one. Every step is noted in their chat.
4. After inspecting, the tenant confirms they've **moved in**, which releases the payment to the landlord and starts the lease.
5. **From the chat:** tapping *View property* in the chat with the landlord shows where the booking stands and the next step: *Book Inspection*, *Pending* while the landlord hasn't accepted the inspection date, *Moved In* once it's confirmed, then *You have successfully rented this property* with *View Tenancy Agreement*.

6. Before moving in, the tenant can ask for a **refund**, or the landlord can reject the booking (a full refund).
7. **Paying monthly** (where the landlord allows it): at Rent Now the tenant chooses *Pay in full* or *Pay monthly* (a twelfth of the yearly rent). Monthly pays the first month now, held the same way until move-in; after that, *Pay Next Month* on the booking (open from 7 days before it's due) pays each month straight to the landlord. They're reminded 3 days before each month is due; a missed month is flagged to both sides. Renewing needs every month of the lease paid.
8. Rent reminders arrive 30, 15 and 0 days before the lease ends; **Renew Lease** pays for the next period. Before anything is charged, the tenant sees exactly what they'll pay, for how many months and until when, and a highlighted note if the rent has gone up since their last payment. If the landlord changes the rent after the tenant has seen that amount, nothing is charged and the tenant is shown the new amount to review. Once the renewal is paid, the lease is extended and the tenancy agreement is updated to the new rent and end date.

Eviction requests

- A landlord can ask to end a current tenancy early from the property's page (*Request eviction*), giving a written reason.
- The tenant is notified and emailed straight away, sees the reason on the booking in Booking History, and can **respond** with their side.
- **Nothing changes** until a HomeServant *super admin* reviews the case and decides. The landlord can withdraw the request while it's under review.
- If approved, the lease ends that day and the property is listed again; the tenancy can't be renewed. If rejected, the tenancy carries on. Both sides are notified and emailed with the decision.

Booking a shortlet

The tenant requests dates; the owner accepts or declines; the tenant then pays, and the payment goes to the owner straight away.

Paperwork

Booking History shows every booking and payment. **Tenancy Agreements** keeps each lease's agreement to view or download, with the date each one was created.

Rating a property

A tenant can rate a property (1–5 stars, from Booking History) only once their payment has been completed and released to the landlord: after moving in for a rental, or once a shortlet's payment has gone to the owner. Until then the booking says *You can rate this property once your payment is completed*.

4. Landlords

- **Payout account first:** a landlord adds a bank account (checked against the bank) before listing.
- **Add a property** from the *Upload a Property* button on the dashboard home (or Profile), with photos, a walkthrough video, price, rooms, lease length (or unit details for a shortlet), whether tenants may message them, and (not for shortlets) whether tenants may **pay monthly**.
- **Changing photos** is limited: 3 changes per listing, after which the photos are locked for 14 days (both set by HomeServant). The edit screen shows how many are left. Deleting the listing and listing it again is always possible unless it's occupied.
- **Hide a listing** (My Properties → ⋮): an unoccupied listing can be hidden from tenants — out of search and not bookable — and shown again any time.
- **Feature a listing** (My Properties → ⋮ → *Feature this listing (ad)*): pay a fee (₦5,000 for 7 days by default) to have it labelled *Featured* and shown in the promoted search spots. Buying again extends it. The fee isn't refundable.
- Monthly tenants: My Properties and the tenant's profile show *paid until* and flag a missed month.
- **My Properties:** search, filter by status and category, sort (price, name, rent expiring), and see each listing's price, rooms, pending requests, tenant and rent expiry at a glance.
- **Incoming Bookings** (dashboard home) shows new requests with the tenant's photo and a line from their booking profile (their *About me*, or hobbies); the tenant's profile shows it in full. A landlord can clear one (×) or all of them from this feed, with Undo; clearing doesn't decline anything, the request stays in Bookings and still counts as waiting for an answer.
- **Bookings:** accept or decline shortlet requests, confirm inspection dates or set one themselves, reject a paid booking (refunding the tenant), view a tenant's profile, and see the rent roll. The *Rent* list shows who is renting now (a shortlet guest drops off once their stay ends; *See all* keeps the full history) and flags monthly rent that is overdue.
- **Change the price** (or lease length) by editing the listing, at any time. Tenants who have booked it are notified with the old and new amounts and what it means for them. Nothing anyone has already paid changes: a tenant who has paid but not moved in keeps their price, and a current tenant keeps theirs until the lease ends. The new rent applies to anyone who hasn't paid yet if they go ahead, and to a current tenant when they renew.
- **Delete a listing** only when nobody lives there and no tenant's money is being held.
- **My Tenants** (dashboard home or Profile): everyone who has rented or paid for a stay, filtered by Current / Former / All and searchable by name, with when they rented and when their rent expires (highlighted within 30 days). Tapping a tenant shows their email, phone, occupation, marital status and every tenancy with that landlord, with *Evict tenant* on a current one. A tenant's phone number is only shown once they have paid for that landlord's property.
- **Request an eviction** from an occupied property's page, with a reason; a super admin must approve it (see Eviction requests above).

Everywhere in the app

- **Pull down to refresh** on the landlord's Home, Bookings, Properties and Messages tabs, the profile pages, and a tenant's home, Booking History and Tenancy Agreements.

- **Always up to date:** changes arrive live. When the app or browser tab comes back to the foreground, or the connection returns after a drop, it fetches anything it missed.
- **Profile photos:** tap anyone's profile photo, wherever it appears, to see it full size.

5. Money: escrow, refunds and payouts

- Payments go through Paystack. Rent is **held** until move-in, then paid out to the landlord's account, minus the platform fee.
- A tenant's own refund before move-in returns the money less a small fee; a landlord's rejection refunds in full.
- Payouts are sent from HomeServant's **Paystack balance**, so it must hold at least the amount being paid out. A payout the balance can't cover waits and is retried automatically every 30 minutes once money is there.
- No one is ever paid or refunded twice, and a payment can't be both paid out and refunded. If a payout or refund doesn't go through (a bank or Paystack problem), the tenant's move-in or stay still goes ahead and a moderator or super admin sees it on the *Payouts & Refunds* screen to retry it, or to refund a tenant who hasn't moved in. After an admin refund, the tenant can't request another.
- Marketplace payments are held until the buyer confirms receipt (or released automatically after 7 days unless disputed).

6. Messaging

- **Tenants and landlords** can message each other once the tenant has **paid** for that property. Before that, a landlord may reach out and the tenant may reply.
- If a booking is **refunded** (by the tenant or a landlord rejection), the chat closes for both sides until the tenant pays again. A notice in the chat says why, and the old messages stay readable.
- Marketplace buyers and vendors message each other about an order.
- Messages show *Sending...*, *Seen*, or *Not sent · Tap to retry*. Photos can be sent.
- Reply to a particular message by swiping it to the right, or by holding it down (right-click on a computer) and choosing *Reply*; *Copy* copies its text. The reply shows the message it answers.
- Once the tenant has paid, their chat with the landlord shows the property at the top with a *View property* button that opens its photos and details over the chat, for both of them. The payment notification opens this chat too, and booking emails include the property's details.
- New messages arrive live; if one sits unread for 15 minutes, the recipient also gets an email.

7. Marketplace: customers and vendors

- **Customers** browse products, order and pay, track orders, and confirm receipt.
- **Vendors** apply with their business details and bank account. Once an admin approves them, their products appear in the marketplace; they manage products, orders and messages, and see their transactions. For a delivery order, *Ship with courier* books the pickup and sends the buyer the tracking number. A removed product can be *put back on sale*.
- Buyers can **report an item** they bought (the flag on its page).

8. Support

- **Contact Support** offers a phone number or a **live chat**. The user first picks what it's about (Payments, Booking, Account, Listing, Marketplace, Other) — the admin sees it at the top of the chat. A spinner shows while the chat opens.
- Admins are shown to the user by **first name** only. An admin may also phone the user about their chat.
- The chat goes straight to an admin who is on duty. If nobody is available, the user is told they're in the queue and will be notified when someone replies; the first admin to come on duty picks it up, and super admins are emailed if it waits 15 minutes.
- If the chat is transferred, a notice says who has it now.
- Either side can end the chat: the admin marks it resolved, or the user taps **End chat**. The user is then asked to rate it (1–5 stars) if an admin replied.

9. Notifications

- In-app: a bell with a count, and banners for new messages, bookings, payments and support updates. Opening a chat clears its notifications.
- Browser notifications: after tapping *Turn on*, notifications arrive even when HomeServant is closed. Signing out stops them on that browser.
- Email: sign-in codes, booking and payment updates, and unread messages.

10. The admin console

A separate web console at `/#/admin-login`, with three levels: Support, Moderator and Super Admin. It covers:

- users, vendors, properties and marketplace moderation;
- reports;
- support chats, with auto-assignment, transfers, internal notes, saved replies, customer details and handling history;
- the admin roster, with search and level filters;
- the activity log;
- **Support Insights** (response times, ratings and workload).

The Admin Guide explains each part and what each level may do.

11. Where to read more

Document	For
Admin Guide	Admins: using the console, levels and permissions, support chats, emergencies.
Frontend Developer Guide	Developers: how the Flutter app is organised and talks to the API.
Backend Developer Guide	Developers: the API's data, endpoints, background jobs, settings, tests and deployment.